"THANKS, I'LL THINK I'LL GO IT ALONE"

One dot-commers' experience seeking employment through professional agencies.

With all the current news stories circulating regarding termination of employment and management trying to lay people off properly and failing, I thought a story regarding what happens after the axe falls was well in order. My exit story is nothing spectacular, a timely CEO sat everyone down three days before Christmas, essentially saying, "we're all leaving early, and we're not coming back - ever."

So, unemployed in the worst possible period to be looking for work -due both to the time of year and the state of the market - I essentially did what any dot-commer would do, post resumes to hits on online job sites. Three weekdays of submissions later, I got the first call. So began my descent into Job Agency Hell.

Being the week of January 1st, most of the individual employers were on vacations and otherwise unavailable, so the majority of my calls that week were from recruiters and agencies that said they were interested in representing me. All told, eight agencies called me in for preliminary interviews. Half were very up-front and stated clearly that they didn't have any jobs matching my skill-set, but planned on seeing some in the next week. The other half claimed to have positions they could rep me to.

By the third week in January - two full weeks after the first agency interview - I started to get very worried about the agencies that were supposedly shopping my resume around. I was still sending my resume to individual companies who posted positions on the board, but what happened to these agencies with 'thousands' of job postings at their disposal? When I found seven postings that met my skill-set listed on an online job board, and realized all seven were posted by an agency that was supposedly looking for positions for me, worry turned to frustration. Calls and e-mails to the agency resulted in a callback from the Director of Business Services, who essentially told me that I was asking for too little money and that my resume wasn't properly entered into the system because the rep I had seen was too new.

I was bemused and incredulous. Frankly, I don't know a single person who would turn down a higher salary than they were asking for, do you? As for the inexperience of the rep, I expect he/she will know their job just as they expect that I know mine before they recommend me to a company for hire. Why didn't another rep step in and help, why didn't anyone call me? I can only imagine what was going on at all the other agencies that chose not to take the time to call me back.

One agency, OTEC.com, did indeed score me an interview for a position I found quite attractive. They were, however, the only agency to ever contact me regarding a possible employment interview in the three weeks since I began my search in earnest. In actuality they were the only other agency to ever voluntarily call me during the entire period I was looking for work.

In the end, I scored six interviews on my own - sending my resume directly to the companies that were hiring instead of to employment agencies. Four of those turned into second interviews, and I quickly accepted one of the offers presented to me about a week later. It amazed me that an individual with limited resources could land so many interviews on his own, while these agencies that claim to represent thousands of opportunities could not even provide me with more than one lead.

So, having been through unemployment hell and back in a little over a month, I can safely say that one should never rely solely on the 'professionals' at employment agencies to find a new job. Hit the boards, use contacts, ask friends and family, and even in this down market you will find that your next position is right around the corner.

Mike Talon is a Windows Systems Consultant and freelance writer who is relieved to find himself back at work in New York City. You can reach him at: MikeTalonNYC@yahoo.com.

@association.news